

My Brother's Keeper

“Am I my brother’s keeper?” — Genesis 4:9

Correcting a man’s faults and telling him the truth about himself is the deepest compassion, and the first duty of anyone who serves him. But he will only hear it from someone who has earned the right.
— after Yamamoto Tsunetomo, Hagakure (c. 1716)

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At three years younger than me, my brother Chris was a solid enough wrestler to earn his way into the University of Pennsylvania on it, and from the time we were kids, he has been the steadiest presence in my life next to our father.

Chris and I have never had a falling out. Not once. You’d assume my addiction would have detonated us. As I hovered around rock bottom, our relationship felt the strain, but it never broke. Not even the night he called and gave me an ultimatum I’ll come back to, the one that finally left me nowhere to stand. I wasn’t angry. I respected him too much to be angry. He loved me enough to tell me the truth when everyone else had run out of it. Through all the pills and the lies and the wreckage, I always knew my brother was trying to save my life. He may be the only person who could have said that sentence and had me actually hear it. That was Tsunetomo’s whole point: the hard truth only lands from someone who has earned the right to say it. Chris had earned it a hundred times over.

Chris drove me to my first detox. Anaheim, before the place in Laguna. It looked like a house on a regular street, with a back office where they did the intake. I sat across the desk answering their questions with drugs hidden in a Flintstones vitamin bottle.. At some point I looked up and caught Chris’s face. He knew. He’d driven me all that way to get me clean, and I’d carried the drugs in through the front door in a child’s vitamin bottle. I still see his face.

After I got sober I talked him into taking a manager job in Pensacola, so for once we were in the same city. Chris is a workaholic, and I don’t mean a guy who works hard, I mean the clinical definition. I’d call him to come out, I’ve got people I want you to meet, and he’d say no, I’ve got to work. Every time. But every so often he’d surface, and when he did he was generous to a fault. Let’s take a trip, he’d say, and the next thing I knew I was in Costa Rica, in a tiny rental Hyundai they had

warned us about at El Volcán, on a road that was less a road than a riverbed of rock. The Hyundai barely made it. So did we. Every trip we took went like that: Chris deciding, me going along.

And then there was India.

India was supposed to be Chris's move, a big job, the kind he takes on without blinking. I'd fly over and spend time with him before he settled in. Then, the day before his flight, he gets Bell's palsy. Half his face just stops working. He calls me in a panic: I can't move the left side of my face, how am I supposed to go to India like this? And I impulsively decided: Chris, I already took the time off. We're going.

I flew out first. Walked out of the airport into the heat and the noise and roughly a million people moving in every direction at once, and thought, very calmly, what have I done. Chris arrived a few days later and we set off, Mumbai, Delhi, Calcutta, Agra. We went up to Dharamsala, where the Dalai Lama lives, and it turned out he was in town. We asked if we could see him. He's meditating, they told us. Hard to argue with that one.

Every photograph of Chris from that trip is taken from behind. Every single one. Half his face was frozen and he refused to be documented, so I came home with a gorgeous collection of pictures from one of the most beautiful places on earth in which my brother appears, in each and every frame, to be in witness protection.

One night at the hotel I asked the front desk if they had anyone who could give me a massage. They said no, then somehow found someone anyway. The man who showed up looked like he'd been pulled off landscaping duty and pointed upstairs. There was a table but nothing for my head, so my neck sat cranked against the end of it like a punishment for asking. Whatever he rubbed on me wasn't massage oil — olive oil, maybe, or something closer to Crisco. It was, without question, the worst massage of my life. When I stood up you could see the grease coming through my pants. I found Chris and said, you are not going to believe what just happened to me.

When Chris got engaged to Nisha, there was never a question I'd be his best man. Planning the bachelor party was another matter. I don't drink, everyone was scattered across the country, and I wasn't moving fast enough for his taste, so his friends Brian and DiBiase ended up booking it themselves, the Grand Baha Mar in the Bahamas. I split a room with my mom's boyfriend Gary to make the number work. Chris put me at the craps table one night and told me to do exactly what he said. I rolled the dice with no idea what I was doing, he called the bets, and the whole table started

winning. A stranger reached over at one point and pressed a thousand-dollar chip into my hand, just for the luck I'd apparently brought him. I still don't entirely understand what happened at that table. I just did what my brother told me.

Chris likes to say that growing up, he and I played Nintendo. We didn't. I played Nintendo. He watched. I never once handed him the controller, not for a turn, not for a single level, and he sat on that floor beside me for hours anyway, waiting on a shot that was never coming. That's the whole thing. He stayed right there even when I gave him nothing to hold.

That's my brother. The Nintendo I hogged, India, the Bahamas, the ultimatum that saved my life. Chris sees what I can't, and when I stop arguing and do what he says, it works out in ways I never would have bet on. My best friend.

Scott's comments on this chapter

Seven notes, in order.

1. At this point, I'm no longer going to reformat your manuscript. I can walk you through what needs to happen before it goes to Jocelyn for editing. I changed the font and used 1.5 spacing to make it easier on my eyes.
2. A scholarship? If so, say so.
3. I'm assuming this will be a scene shortly. If that's so, delete this. Don't tell us what you're going to show us. It's redundant. Trust the story.
4. SHOW this as a scene. You're bouncing around a lot in your story, telling the end (i.e., here's what you need to know about Chris, "he drove me to my first detox," etc. Replace this with a scene. Did he tell you that you needed detox, or did you tell him? Did he offer to take you, or tell you he was taking you? Describe the car he drove. How did you feel in his car? What were you telling yourself while you drove? What did you talk about? You get there. Describe the person doing your intake. Where did you sit? Chris? Do you see what I mean? Cut all of this narration and put the reader in your shoes and behind your eyes. The narration is good, but it's not visual and compelling. See this as if it were a movie. Use narration to fill in details, not to tell everything.
5. If I told you I got shot in the head while driving down the street and started the next paragraph with, "And after I recovered, I..." you'd say, "Wait a minute? You just got shot in the head. What happened?" That's what you're doing each time you hint at a problem, a bottom, and then you release the suspense and tension by taking the reader past the pain or onto another topic. You did both here. 1. You went from trying to sneak drugs into treatment, and 2. you talk about your workaholic brother who called the shots when the two of you vacationed. You can't build momentum by letting up on the pressure. The reader needs to get a sense that you were living on borrowed time, pushing insanity in your addiction, nearing death with your ongoing behavior. But the way it's written, it's like you're a Disney, and you've just looked at a scary ride. But you didn't get on it. You just watched. And then you turned your head to watch bumper cars. By this point in your story, the reader should be wondering if your story was finished posthumously after you died from an overdose. I don't get any of that tension. You've done a nice job of making the reader care about you, but the back and forth chronology doesn't represent the slide of a partier into an out of control addict.
6. Now you're in India? And you're post recovery? I don't understand the timeline. The chapter title fits what you're writing about, but this is now an autobiography of semi-interesting stories that have no focus on your theme: addiction/recovery.
7. Good story, but you left it hanging. Unless he laughed or added something interesting to your story, cut.